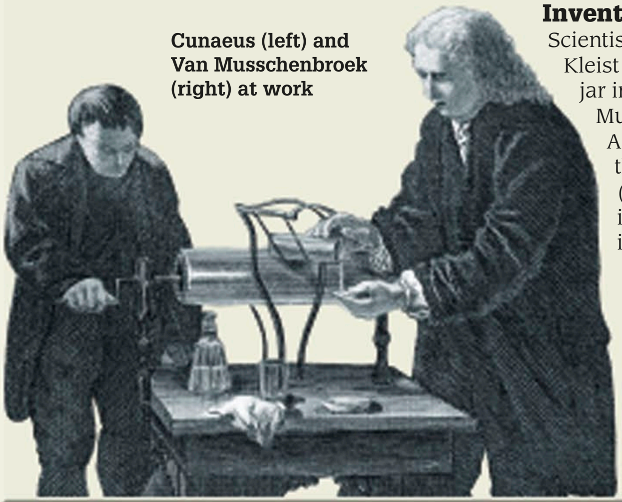
1745 STORING ELECTRICITY

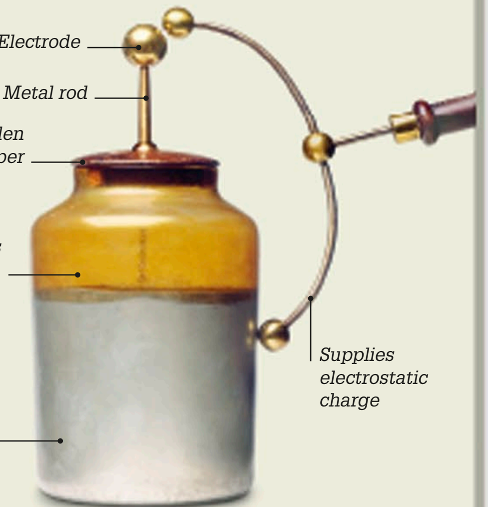
The Leyden jar was the first device able to store a static electric charge built up by a friction generator, while also being capable of releasing it later. It was not a battery as it did not produce a charge itself, but it was a handy way of storing electricity. Benjamin Franklin used Leyden jars in his experiments with electricity (see p.100).

Leyden jar
The glass jar had a foil lining on the inside and around the outside. It stored a static charge between two electrodes, one at the external end of a brass rod passing through the stopper, the other inside the jar.



Cunaeus (left) and Van Musschenbroek (right) at work

Inventing the Leyden jar
Scientist Ewald Georg von Kleist created the first Leyden jar in Germany. Pieter van Musschenbroek and Andreas Cunaeus from the Dutch city of Leiden (the English spelling is Leyden) developed it further.



1742 — 1746 — 1750

Steller's sea cow (top) with eared seals and a sea otter (bottom right)

1741

Arctic voyage

Danish explorer Vitus Bering died when his ship was wrecked off the coast of Alaska. The naturalist on this expedition, Georg Steller, survived and discovered six new animal species. Among them was Steller's sea cow, a large sea mammal that was extinct by 1767.

1742

Celsius scale

Anders Celsius, a Swedish astronomer and mathematician, devised a temperature scale in which the boiling point and freezing point of water were set 100 degrees apart. It developed into the modern Celsius scale. On Celsius's original scale, 100° signified the freezing point and 0° the boiling point, instead of the other way around, as used today.

Woodpecker from Buffon's *Natural History*

1749

Animal studies

French naturalist Georges Buffon began publishing *Natural History*, a work that eventually stretched to 44 volumes. Buffon was one of the first people to realize that our planet is very ancient and that many species have disappeared since it was formed.